

THE BIG FRAUD INDIAN WEDDING

In Maharashtra, the 'noble' practice of mass marriages is fast turning into a money-making exercise and a ploy to garner votes

■ By Prerana Thakurdesai

Marriages are made in heaven—goes the adage, but in Maharashtra the human hand has a bigger role to play when it comes to this institution. Politicians in the state have taken it upon themselves to get the underprivileged married, not just once but twice, sometimes even with their children in tow.

This 'noble' practice of mass marriages is now fast turning into a money-making venture for organisers and a ploy to generate votes. In December 2003, the state Government introduced the 'Kanyadan' scheme for the benefit of the scheduled castes and tribes, who could not afford to have a wedding ceremony. The Social Justice Department of the state Government provides Rs 10,000 worth mangalsutra and utensils to each newly-wed couple. Local NGOs assist in organising these annual grand events and distributing gifts to the couples. Since 2003, the funds allocated under this scheme have more than doubled, from Rs 2.20 crore to Rs 5 crore. In fact, the district administration in Vidarbha has applied for a mention in the *Guinness Book of World Records* for conducting 927 marriages, the highest in any region last year.

In a bid to get more and more couples married, the administration has got existing married couples to tie the knot again at several mass marriage functions. Sources reveal that over 60 per cent of the couples who participated in the ceremony at Gadchiroli this March were already married. For instance, Punesh Giridhar Shivram, 30, a tractor driver from Gurusvala village, got married in 2002. In December 2006, some representatives of the district administration visited his village and took down some names. "They told us that

we (tribals) are entitled to certain benefits. We had to attend a function without our children," says Shivram. He says that a wedding ceremony was performed and he was given a mangalsutra and some household supplies. The father of two daughters, aged five and two, also added that there were 10 other married pairs from his village who were remarried in the same ceremony. "There was even a woman breast-feeding her infant while her marriage ceremony was in progress," narrates an astonished Shivram.

His is not an isolated case. Despite their marriage of three years and one-year-old daughter, Santosh Madavi and



SANTOSH AND WIFE TANIIJA, remarried in a mass marriage ceremony, despite being married for three years and having a one-year-old daughter.



LEKHCHAND AND WIFE MEENATAI, remarried, in front of their four-year-old son, as they were instructed to do so by a police officer.



wife Tanija, from Urandi village, were remarried in a similar ceremony in November 2006. Again, Lekhchand Salane, 31, from Potegaon village married Meenatai, 28, in the presence of their four-year-old son. "A policeman instructed us to get married and we obliged as we had nothing to lose," explains Madavi.

The government regulation on mass marriages clearly states that the district administration must verify through a signed affidavit that a couple is not already married. Practically, this rarely happens. Tribal rights activist Paromita Goswami recently witnessed such a profane practice at Chandrapur. "During the ceremony, I saw six couples mingling very comfortably with each other. This is unusual behaviour for mass marriages as the bride and groom are barely acquainted," says Goswami. After probing, she concluded that the couples were already married. They were asked to remarry with the promise of gifts from a visiting minister. "We raised a hue and cry at the function and the officials were forced to apologise," says Goswami.